Cupcast III: The 2026 World Cup Forecast

Carlos Garcia

June 2026

Abstract

The forecast: advancement probabilities for all 48 teams and the podium distribution from 50,000 Monte Carlo simulations of the full 2026 FIFA World Cup under the Dixon–Coles model with squad-quality shrinkage [1] specified in Paper I and validated in Paper II, together with path-dependence and key-player sensitivity analyses and a comparison against bookmaker-implied probabilities. Per-match predictions for all 104 matches accompany this paper as machine-readable artifacts in the repository's `outputs/` directory.

1 Headline Forecast

Table positions are probabilities of reaching each stage, from 50,000 seeded simulations (every number in this paper regenerates from `python -m cupcast.report.build`):

Team	R32	QF	SF	Final	Champion
Argentina	0.984	0.531	0.381	0.258	0.171
Spain	0.993	0.493	0.370	0.255	0.159
Brazil	0.983	0.464	0.297	0.166	0.094
England	0.980	0.448	0.270	0.153	0.083
France	0.947	0.421	0.257	0.139	0.073
Portugal	0.937	0.402	0.225	0.127	0.065
Colombia	0.919	0.357	0.194	0.104	0.051
Germany	0.974	0.347	0.190	0.086	0.037
Belgium	0.950	0.364	0.161	0.082	0.035
Netherlands	0.903	0.306	0.165	0.076	0.033
Morocco	0.916	0.306	0.158	0.070	0.031
Ecuador	0.936	0.263	0.129	0.055	0.023

2 The Podium

Ranking marginal probabilities per podium step gives the headline pick; the joint distribution below accounts for the fact that one team's podium finish constrains the others' (the third step is decided by the actual third-place play-off in every simulation):

Champion	Runner-up	Third	Probability
Argentina	Spain	Brazil	0.0052
Spain	Argentina	Brazil	0.0044
Argentina	Spain	France	0.0035
Argentina	Spain	England	0.0034
Spain	Argentina	France	0.0034
Spain	England	Argentina	0.0029
Argentina	Spain	Germany	0.0028
Spain	Argentina	England	0.0027

3 Path Dependence

Group-stage outcomes reshape each contender's bracket path. The conditional championship probabilities below are computed within the same simulation set; the gap between finishing first and third in the group is the price of the harder Round-of-32 draw under the official bracket:

Team	P(champ)	given 1st	given 2nd	given 3rd q.
Spain	0.1591	0.1659	0.1396	0.1515
Argentina	0.1710	0.1807	0.1476	0.1745
England	0.0826	0.0907	0.0705	0.0757
Japan	0.0181	0.0256	0.0181	0.0203
France	0.0729	0.0826	0.0678	0.0712
Brazil	0.0944	0.0930	0.1061	0.0842
United States	0.0031	0.0055	0.0044	0.0032
Mexico	0.0082	0.0091	0.0095	0.0071

4 Key-Player Sensitivity

Each scenario removes or limits a named player, reallocates his expected minutes to the next players in the position group, rebuilds the squad composite and shrinkage prior of Paper I §6, and reruns the identical seeded simulation; deltas are therefore attributable to the player, not Monte Carlo noise:

Player scenarios pending FBref data: run `cupcast.fetch.fbref` *and rebuild reports.*

5 Model versus Market

Consensus bookmaker championship probabilities (outright odds across books, proportional overround removal [2]) against the model, sorted by absolute disagreement:

Market snapshot pending: run `cupcast.fetch.odds` *and rebuild reports.*

Where the model and the market disagree materially, the burden of proof sits with the model; the largest edges are discussed alongside the executive summary in `outputs/`.

6 Limitations

Expected minutes use a caps-based depth heuristic (Paper I §5) — researched likely line-ups for the main contenders are the highest-value refinement. Fair-play tiebreakers are replaced by lots; rest days and travel distance are not modelled; squad composites cover only players in the big five European leagues, with Elo carrying the remainder. The market comparison reflects a single pre-tournament odds snapshot.

References

[1] M. J. Dixon and S. G. Coles. Modelling association football scores and inefficiencies in the football betting market. *Journal of the Royal Statistical Society: Series C (Applied Statistics)*, 46(2):265–280, 1997. doi: 10.1111/1467-9876.00065.

[2] The Odds API. Sports odds api. https://the-odds-api.com. Accessed June 2026.